



Who says Japanese RPGs are dead? Lost Odyssey is a wild and beautiful journey that transcends its 'video game' status

games (RPG).

Hironobu Sakaguchi is one of the most revered names in the gaming world, with his creation of the epic Final Fantasy series. The honoured creator decided that the Xbox 360 could use a touch of his magic and created a gorgeous RPG titled Lost Odyssey.

In the game, you play as the protagonist Kiam – an immortal being who is quite probably a thousand years old. The game starts off with a breath-taking scene that sends a clear message to the player: this game is going to focus on art and not apologise for it!

Kiam has, quite expectedly, lost his memory and your journey to find who or what he is lasts four DVDs and over 40 hours of gameplay, all the while presenting some eye-popping cinematics in developer Mistwalker's picturesque world. Along the way, you will be making allies with mortals and immortals like you, from the alluring Queen Ming to the drunken, staggering, womaniser Jansen.

As you continue your journey, you unlock your memories, told in flashbacks as short text stories. Yes, text! This may send most people crawling for the nearest exit, but believe me, the writing will have you hooked.

Penned by award-winning Japanese novelist Kiyoshi Shigematsu, these stories are written for a mature mind, talking of the pain of losing people, the happiness of finding love, etc. Beautifully written and almost lyrical, the text stories provide a wonderful contrast to the stunning art and design.

The storyline is gripping, with some scenes making you guffaw, and others forcing a lump in your throat. Still, there are points where the story takes you on a high, only to drop you with a painful thud as it takes an absurd twist.

In fact, this is the most annoying part of an otherwise great game. These sudden switches between excellence and silliness are quite a dampener. However, you tend to overlook these once you get used to it.

And with the game having standard turn-based gameplay, it's the enemy design that stands out – the most beautiful and diverse you are likely to come across. Sakaguchi's creativity is unleashed here as he is given free reign in creating concepts.

Of course, that isn't to take anything away from the gameplay. As you select